

# CHAMBERS'S JOURNAL

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CONDUCTED BY R. CHAMBERS (SECUNDUS)

No. 150.—VOL. III.

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 13, 1886.

PRICE 1½d.

## THE PORTABLE THEATRE.

A FEW wagon-loads of large and square wooden shutters; numerous poles of various lengths; a quantity of seat-planks and their supports; some scene-painted canvas wrapped around long rollers, some nailed and glued upon framework; a collection of ropes and pulleys; various 'stage properties'; two open coke-fire grates; an amount of dark and soiled drapery and cheap carpeting, and a mass of other things—meet these on the highway, and you may know that a portable theatre is shifting its quarters.

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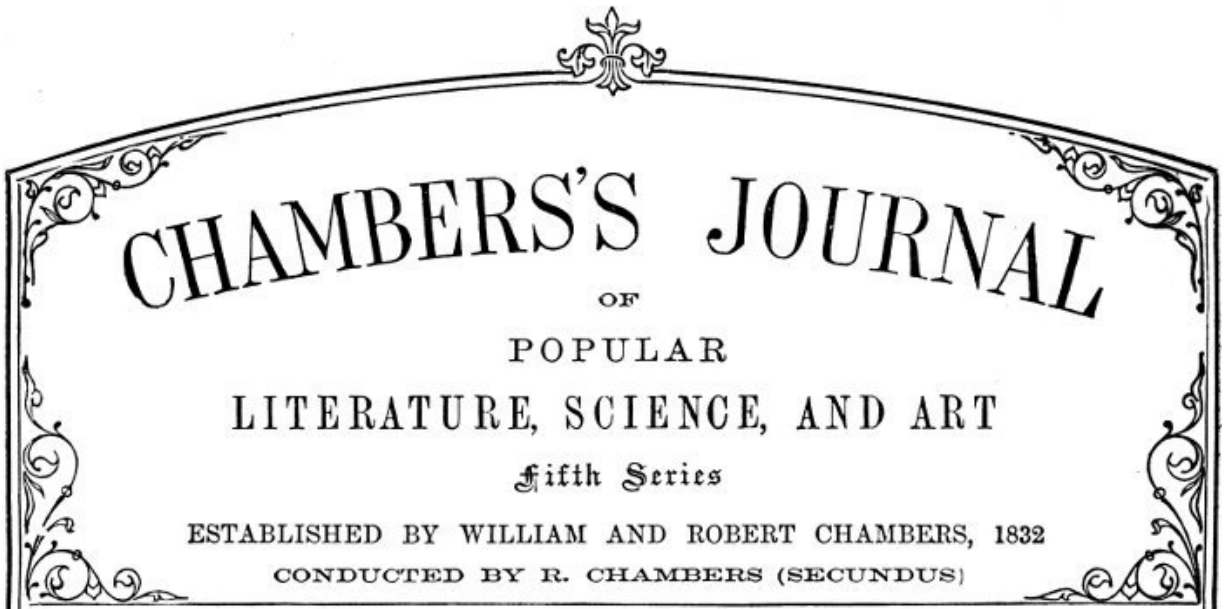
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His wife, when not in the cast, or his offspring, or a decrepit father, are generally assigned to the post of money-taker at the theatre door. The



company are supposed to have a check against them by appointing as their representatives those who collect the tickets. The person who receives the cash from the public as they enter is familiarly known to the fraternity by the name of 'first robber.'

Now, many who know the business have been heard to declare that the manager seldom loses—if ever—and generally gains, however slack business may be, and even while his fellow-actors are pinched for necessities. If it is asked, 'Why do the workers agree to such an arrangement?' it may be replied: 'The proprietor and manager is master in his own establishment; and those who won't conform to the rules of the theatre may go and make way for those who will.'

Altogether, portable actors, or, as many of the labouring classes prefer to call them, showfolk, make but a precarious living, and they have often many troubles, for which they receive little sympathy. At times they are heard speaking of how some years ago, during the fair at a certain town, they performed five times during the day, and individually amassed three pounds seven shillings for the day's work. But that was a rare occurrence, and they dwell with pleasure upon the memory of it. The usual share in ordinary times rises to five shillings nightly during good business, and perhaps as much as seven or eight on the Saturday, and very often it drops to the amount of but a few coppers. There is all the excitement of chance in this mode of remuneration, and that may offer an inducement to some speculative minds. If trade is bad, or the people are too poor or anti-theatrical, the strolling Thespian may find that his reward after work is something less than a shilling, and upon that he may have to feed and lodge himself until the next night brings a further supply.

Many who dwell in towns think that the portable theatre is now little more than a remnant of a bygone age, that the drama has cast off this itineracy; and such thinkers would doubtless be surprised if they were shown a list of the playhouses that move about the country. They are certainly very numerous. These buildings seldom look well in the morning light; there is a dissipated look about them, as though they kept bad hours. This more particularly applies to the interior, to whose good appearance the glare of gas is very essential. When the actors assemble for rehearsal, which is generally at eleven o'clock, the drapery looks dull and tawdry, the woodwork seems rough, the sawdust over the earth-floor is dirty, and the

scenes appear daubs. If there be a little breeze astir, the canvas roofing overhead will flap with a sound like that of the sails of a ship at sea. The curtain and scene-cloths are rolled up, that the dust may not settle upon them.

When the players have gathered together, rehearsal commences. They seem a motley group. There is the proprietor and manager, a portly man, who is troubled with occasional rheumatism—which he calls gout; he wears a heavy moustache and a heavy gold albert, and has much power of voice—which at times is decidedly throaty. There is the low comedian, who is small of stature, with an expansive face deeply lined; his legs are misshapen, and he walks with the gait of one who suffers the affliction of many corns and bunions. Naturally, his countenance has the most serious aspect of any one in the company; but usage has trained it otherwise; he would be a melancholy man were it not that he gained his living by provoking mirth, and has a reputation to keep up. In his youth, his soul aspired to tragedy, but his legs were against it. Within his quaint figure he holds more sentiment than many of his companions of more symmetrical mould, and he professes to be a diligent and critical reader. He values ‘low comedy’ now, because it has many advantages; it gains an extra half-share, makes him popular with the audience, and secures him the best benefit in each town.

The middle-aged man with the stiff carriage, and with the hair grown long and well oiled and curved, so that at the bottom it lies like a roll upon the neck, is the ‘heavy man,’ who claims the chief-villain parts; he glories in his deep tones and in his dark scowl. It seems he does not much admire the smooth-faced scoundrels of the drama; you cannot mistake the villainy *he* portrays; directly he enters the stage, you say, ‘That is the villain of the piece.’ And he is not without a speciality in his particular line of business; to use his own words—‘He likes his scoundrel’s “game;” no chicken-hearted repentance at the end of the last act.’ His favourite final exit speech is thus: ‘Ah! soh, you have counterplotted and balked me. But I-a haave played a bold and desper-rat game, and now I leave you with contempt-a! My curses light-a ’pon ye!’ If, however, he is killed when villainy has done its allotted work, he makes the most of his death, and invariably dies with a terrific backward fall. He has been heard to complain that in his stage career he receives small encouragement; ‘for,’ argues he, ‘after my heavy night’s

work, anybody may come on with a stuffed stick and knock me down, and they'll get all the applause.'

One of the company is a young man whose face has already lost its pristine freshness; he wears his hat with an inclination to the right, and looks to be a knowing, wayward, idle, and thriftless wanderer. A great amount of cheap beer enters into his idea of life. He drinks this liquor at any hour; and when counting his cash, calculates it not by pence, but by the half-pints it represents. He is a weed who benefits nobody, not even himself. Enough has been said about him.

The man who throughout his life has never ceased to do his best, honestly and cheerfully, and has failed through no fault of his own, must be worthy of some respect. This has been the way of the old gentleman—he may be called that—whose age is more than any other of the company. In his work he is painstaking, even amid the inartistic surroundings of a portable theatre. He now possesses an extensive stage wardrobe, gathered for his own private use; it is the collection of years, and he is proud of it. You won't hear him speak so often of his own future now, but he is always chattering about what he thinks his daughter will do. She is a darling girl, he says, and will be the blessing of his old age.

His daughter matches well with the morning sunshine. A fresh, rosy-faced girl, with shining hair and laughing eyes, in great contrast to these yellow women and blue-chinned men. She always shows neatness and good taste. Her father has often told her that they are merely 'birds of passage' in this cheap playhouse, and she is anxiously anticipating their migration. If that indulgent old dad of hers isn't careful, she'll become a vain young woman.

As this girl is now, so was at one time that blear-eyed, bedraggled woman, who seems to prefer sitting to standing and idling to working. She is untidy and careless, and walks out with her boots unbrushed. Her rising this morning is yet quite a recent affair; traces of sleep still cling to her eyes. Not many years ago, she was as fair and modest as the old man's daughter is now, and not a soul anticipated such a change. Who can answer that the other may not alter likewise?

The man who is hammering at some repair to the building is the degenerated female's husband, and candour must confess that he looks it. He has many of his wife's characteristics; the same dissipated face, impolite

manner at times, and general attitude of discontent. But these parallel ways of theirs are not productive of concord; quite the contrary, for, as one of their acquaintance tersely observes, 'They quarrel like old boots,' a simile which must be more fantastic than correct.

Among the company is an old woman who only needs the sugar-loaf-shaped hat to resemble the familiar pictures of a witch. She is indigenous to the portable theatre, was cradled in one, and knows little of any life beyond it. Her daughter is that scraggy, uncanny-looking young female, whose dominant passion at present is jealousy of the old man's daughter, whom she never ceases to malign.

The rehearsal here is not generally a long ceremony. A partial or complete repetition of the words, and a comparing of notes respecting the various entrances, exits, and general business of the play, and that is all. Then the healthy-minded people do their marketing, and go off for a short walk. The others continue to 'hang about.'

The audience that comes here likes its dramatic food strong—no parlour comedies and talky dramas, but plenty of incident, of action, passions, stirring speeches, combats, and a little coloured fire burned off the wings. The probability of the sequence of events as here dramatically represented, or the possibility of their occurrence at all, are not matters which trouble the mind of either the actor or his audience. In the matter of denouements the author's published idea is quite regularly departed from in the portable theatre, and of greatest playwrights' masterpieces it is frequently said: 'Oh, we can bring the curtain down better than that.' So, directly vice is unmasked with a taste of punishment, the virtuous gather together—perhaps without explanation of why they were so near—and the hero spouts a short speech in a victorious spirit, and thus—finale.

At one travelling theatre where the manager followed the usual custom of announcing during each evening the succeeding night's programme, the drama in question had been billed. In the managerial speech occurred the following words: 'I have very great pleasure in announcing for next Thursday night the production, for the first time during our visit, of the favourite play, entitled *Maria Martin, or the Murder at the Red Barn*. I have further pleasure in stating that the version we play has *never* been

performed in this town; and was written expressly for this company by a relative of the Martin family, and has been secured by me at great expense.'

This information was received with much satisfaction and applause; that it had had the desired effect was proved conclusively by a view of the Thursday night's house. And the gentleman faithfully kept his promise, for he played a version that had certainly never been performed in that town; he introduced into the drama as usually given, a part of a gypsy family of vengeful proclivities, and so got two sets of murders, and as both were constantly repeated in visions, it may be supposed the audience had a fair dose of dramatic crime for its money.

But there is many a good performance to be seen in a portable theatre; and extremely good, when the surroundings are considered. The writer remembers a very creditable performance of the play of *Hamlet*—given one dreadfully wild night in a portable that was not the best of its kind. The rain had penetrated the roof in many places before the performance began, and the wind had been all day threatening to blow off the tilt. With the combined damp and cold, it was a very undesirable task to don long hose and thin velvet shirts, and to wear them for three hours in such a draughty and rain-sodden place. But this discomfort was necessary there, as a slight mitigation of a state of poverty. Perhaps there was a want of repose in the acting that night, for it was advisable to dodge those places where the water found the roof weakest, and so descended as from a spout. The Ghost, who had a cold, coughed during his scenes in a most unspectral manner. In the 'play-scene' there was a crash, and it was feared the tilt was gone, and one of the courtiers ran out to see what had given way. Two of the rope-fastenings were loose and flying about wildly. They were secured during the performance, but not without some trouble, each male actor throwing a coat over his shoulders, and giving a hand when the scene in progress did not require him. But as these were fastened, others broke, and it was altogether a night of trouble. Before the last act was reached, there was little to be gained by dodging; the rain penetrated steadily all over, and would fall on heads and run down backs and disturb projecting noses, wherever their owners stood. Hamlet died on a damp couch that night, for the stage carpet was soaked and flooded, but he would be artistic and die lying full length. I can testify that the Horatio, who had to kneel and support the Prince's head, wished he would die quicker. But 'The rest is silence,' came at last; and

Hamlet jumped up again, and then looked radiantly happy; for just as the curtain was descending, one of the audience stood and threw to the actor a rose. It was a pretty compliment, and the recipient deserved it.

When the audience had dispersed, the actors received their reward—fifteenpence each. They deserved it. But their labour was not yet ended for the day. The rain had abated, but the wind lashed with greater force and blew with louder voice. ‘Nothing short of a miracle will save that roof to-night,’ said somebody. So its safety had to be guarded; that is, the company were to attend in turns and keep watch, two or three at a time. One of the coke-fires in the auditorium was replenished, and round it the men sat, talking of absent acquaintances, recounting the peculiarities of some, and giving anecdotes; while above their heads the swaying of the canvas sounded loud, and the wind whirled in fury round the creaking shutters. And thus, as they drowsily sit, wishing for rest, we will leave them.

# BY ORDER OF THE LEAGUE.

## CHAPTER XIII.

FOR a time, Enid stood looking at the sufferer sadly, and wondering where the friends of the poor girl might be. Gradually, as the scene came back to her, she remembered the words of Lucrece, and turned to her. 'Lucrece, did I hear you say you knew this poor woman?'

'Indeed, yes, miss. Three years ago, in Paris, Linda and I were great friends—what you English call "chums." She was an actress at the "Varieties"—a clever player; but she could not rise. Jealousy and a bad husband prevented that. Poor Linda, she has all the talent!'

'Strange that you should know her; but still fortunate. Perhaps, through you, we may be able to discover where her friends are.'

'Poor child! she has no friends.—But hush! See! she has opened her eyes.'

The sufferer was looking wildly around. She tried to rise, but the pain and weakness were too great, and she sank back with a deep fluttering sigh. As she collected her senses—'Where am I?' she asked faintly. 'How did I come here?'

'Do not distress yourself,' Enid said softly. 'You are quite safe. You had an accident, and they brought you here.'

For a moment the girl closed her eyes. 'I remember now. I was knocked down by a cab. But I am better now. Let me get up. Where is my boy?' she continued—'what has become of my boy?'

'Do not trouble yourself about your child,' Enid said soothingly, marvelling that one apparently so young should be a mother. 'He shall be well cared for. Tell us where he is, and he shall be brought to you.'

'You are so good—so good and beautiful! You will find a card in my jacket-pocket where to send for him. Tell me, bright angel of goodness, what is the name they know you by?'

‘My name is Enid Charteris,’ she replied, smiling a little at the theatrical touch, earnest though it was.—‘I must not let you talk any longer. The doctor was very strict about that.’

At the mention of the name, the sick woman became strangely agitated, so much so that Enid was alarmed. ‘Am I in Grosvenor Square? Are you the daughter of Sir Geoffrey Charteris?’

‘Yes, yes. But you really must be quiet now.’

But instead of complying with this request, the stranger burst into a fit of hysterical crying, weeping and sobbing as if her heart would break. ‘Miserable woman that I am!’ she cried, ‘what have I done? Oh, what have I done? O that I could have known before!’

Enid looked at Lucrece in alarm. The outbreak was so sudden, so unexpected, that for a moment they were too startled to speak.

‘She is unhinged by the shock,’ Enid whispered. ‘Perhaps if you were to speak to her, it would have a good effect.’

‘Yes, madam. But if I may be allowed to make a suggestion—I should say it was better if you left the room for a time. She sees some likeness to you, or fancies she does, to some one. She knows me; and if you will leave for a short time, I will try and soothe her.’

‘I think you are right, Lucrece. I will come in again presently, when she has become quieter.’

Directly Enid quitted the apartment, Lucrece’s whole manner changed from the subdued domestic to the eager sympathetic friend. She bent over the bed and looked down in the suffering woman’s eyes. ‘Linda! do you not know me? It is I, Lucrece!’

‘You—and here? What is the meaning of this, and in the dress of a servant? Tell me,’ she continued eagerly. ‘You are not one of his friends in his pay, to help his vile schemes?’

‘I do not know who *he* is. I am here for a good purpose—to protect my mistress from a great harm.’

‘Ah, then, you are no friend of Le Gautier’s.—Do you ever see him? Does he come here often? Do you know what he is after?’



Lucrece started. 'What do you know of Le Gautier?'

'What do I know of him? Everything that is bad, and bitter, and fiendish! But he will not succeed, if I have to sacrifice my life to aid the beautiful lady who has been so kind to me.'

'You are not the only one who would,' Lucrece quietly answered. 'Tell me what you know.'

'I did not know then how good and noble she is.—My head is queer and strange, Lucrece; I cannot tell you now. To-morrow, perhaps, if I am better, I will tell you everything. I am glad now that they brought me here.'

Meanwhile, Maxwell was pacing about the drawing-room, having entirely forgotten the unfortunate woman in his own perplexity. He had been there perhaps half an hour, when Enid entered. She was not too occupied to notice the moody, thoughtful frown upon his face.

'What a sad thing for her, poor woman!' she said.—'How did it happen, Fred?'

'Poor woman?' Maxwell asked vaguely. 'How did what happen?'

'Why, Fred, what is the matter with you?' Enid exclaimed with vague alarm. 'How strange you look! Surely you have not forgotten the poor creature you brought here not more than half an hour ago?'

Maxwell collected himself by a violent effort. 'I had actually forgotten. I was thinking of something else.—Enid, dear, I am going away!'

'Going away! Any one would think, from the expression of your face and the tone of your voice, you were never going to return. Where are you going?'

There was a very considerable chance of his not returning, he felt, and he smiled at the grim idea. 'I am not going far—at least not very far, in this age of express trains and telegraphs. I wish I could take you with me, darling; for I am going to a place you have often longed to see—I am going to Rome.'

'To Rome? Is it not very sudden? You never told me before.'

'Well, it is rather sudden. I have not known it long. You see, I could not tell you a thing I was ignorant of myself.'

‘I wish you were not going,’ Enid said reflectively. ‘I have a feeling that some evil will come of this. And yet I suppose you must go. Is it business of your own, Fred?’

Maxwell hesitated. He could not prevaricate with those clear truthful eyes looking up so earnestly to his own. The soul of honour himself, he could not forgive the want of it in others; but he temporised now. ‘Well, not exactly my own,’ he stammered, trying to make the best of a bad case, ‘or I would not go. It is a secret, which I cannot tell even you; but I shall not be long away.’

‘A secret which you cannot tell even me,’ Enid repeated mechanically. ‘Then it must be something you are very much ashamed of.’

‘Indeed, it is not,’ Maxwell began eagerly, hesitated, and stopped. After all, she was right. It was a secret, a terrible, shameful secret, against which all the manliness in him revolted. For a time he was silent, hanging down his head for very shame, as the whole force of his position came upon him. For the first time, he realised where his rashness had led him, and what he was about to lose.

Enid looked at him in amazement, strangely mixed with a terrible and nameless fear. ‘Fred!’ she cried at length, white and trembling, ‘you are going away upon the mission of that awful League! You cannot deny it.—O Fred! Fred!’

He tried to soothe her as she lay sobbing in his arms, but to no avail. The most fervent promises and the most endearing words she heeded not, crying that he was going from her never to return; and her fears were strengthened when he mournfully but firmly declined to speak of his mission. Presently, when she grew a little calmer, she raised her wet cheeks to him and kissed him. She was pale now, but confident, and striving with all the artifices in her power to persuade him from his undertaking; but tears and prayers, threats even, could not avail.

He shook his head sadly. ‘I would that I could stay with you, Enid,’ he said at length, holding her close in his arms; ‘but this much I can tell you—that I dare not disobey. It is as much as my life is worth.’

‘And as much as your life is worth to go,’ echoed the sobbing girl. ‘What is life to me without you? And now this thing has come between us, parting us

perhaps for ever!’

‘I hope not,’ Maxwell smiled cheerfully. ‘I trust not, darling. My time away is very short; and doubtless I shall not be called upon again for a time—perhaps never.’

Enid dried her eyes bravely and tried to smile. ‘Good-bye, Fred,’ she said brokenly; ‘and heaven grant that my fears are groundless! If anything happened to you, I believe I should die.’

‘I shall come back, darling.—And now, good-bye, and God bless you.’

After he was gone, Enid threw herself down upon the lounge and wept.

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Le Gautier’s star was in the ascendant. His only dangerous rival would soon be hundreds of miles away on a hazardous mission, out of which, in all human probability, he could not come unscathed, even if he escaped with life; a prospective father-in-law wholly in his power; and a bride *in posse*, upon whose fears he could work by describing graphically her father’s danger, with the moral, that it would be her duty to her parent to wed his preserver, Le Gautier. This, in fine, was the pretty scheme the wily adventurer had sketched out in his busy brain, a scheme which at present looked like being brought to a successful issue.

Another source of congratulation to this inestimable young man was the progress he was making with the fair stranger, known to him as Marie St Jean. By the time a fortnight had passed, he had been in Ventnor Street more than once, and quite long enough to feel a passion stronger than he had ever experienced before. It was absolutely dangerous to him, he knew, to be with her so often; but like the moth and the candle, the attraction was so great that he found it impossible to keep away—not that he lost his head for a moment, though he well knew that Marie St Jean could turn him round her finger; but he had formed his plans even here. The first step was to betray the League—the scheme was not quite ripe yet, and the news of Maxwell uncertain—and then take Marie St Jean for a tour upon the continent. There would be plenty of time to return and marry Enid

afterwards without any unnecessary bother; for he had already made up his mind that Miss St Jean was too proud to show her wrongs to the world.

On the Monday afternoon following Maxwell's departure, Le Gautier turned his steps in the direction of Grosvenor Square, feeling on good terms with himself and all mankind. His schemes were prospering hugely. It was clearly useless, he determined, now to hesitate any longer; the blow must be struck, and the sooner the better for all parties concerned. With this intention upmost in his mind, he trippingly ascended the steps of Sir Geoffrey's house and knocked.

He found the baronet in the library, engaged as usual over some volume of deep spiritualistic research; the thing had become a passion with him now, and every spare moment was spent in this morbid amusement. He was getting thin and haggard over it, and Le Gautier thought he looked very old and careworn as he watched him now.

'You have come just in time,' he cried, placing a paper-knife in the book and turning eagerly to Le Gautier. 'I have a passage here that I am unable to understand. Listen to this.'

'I have something more important to speak of,' Le Gautier interrupted. 'I have something more pressing on hand than that attractive subject. Sir Geoffrey, next week I am summoned to Warsaw.'

The baronet began to feel anxious; he knew perfectly well what was coming, and, like all weak men, he dreaded anything like evil. The part that he had to play was a despicable one, and he feared his daughter's angry scorn. Like a recalcitrant debtor, he began to cry for time, the time that never comes. 'So you informed me last week,' he replied, twisting a paper-knife in his hands uneasily. 'I hope you will have a pleasant journey. How long do you expect to be detained there?'

'I cannot tell; it depends upon the amount of business to be done. I may be away six weeks; but, at the very least, I do not see how I can get back to England under the month.'

Sir Geoffrey's face lighted, in spite of his air of regret. Le Gautier noticed this; nothing escaped the ken of those keen black eyes.

'And when you return, we will complete our little arrangements,' Sir Geoffrey exclaimed cheerfully. 'No hurry, you know, no haste in such

matters as these; and, referring to our previous conversation, we cannot be too careful in treading such uncertain ground. Enid'——

'Precisely,' Le Gautier interrupted. 'With all due deference to your opinion, there is need of action, which is a very different matter from that raw haste which your poet tells us is half-sister to delay. I must have something definite settled before I leave England.'

'Pon my honour, you know, you young men are very hasty,' the baronet fidgeted; 'there is no controlling you. In my time, things were quite different; men professed a certain deference to women, and did not take so much for granted as you do now'——

'Sir Geoffrey,' Le Gautier interrupted again, 'things change; men alter; but perfect love is the same for all time. I love your daughter, and would make her my wife.'

In spite of the baronet's feeble-mindedness, there was always something in the Frenchman's higher flights which jarred upon his nerves, a sense of insincerity, a certain hollow, grotesque mockery, which pained him. The last word struck upon him like some chords played out of tune. Still the spell was upon him; he had nought to do but obey.

'We perfectly understand that,' he replied, 'and therefore need say no more about it. You have my promise; indeed, how can it be otherwise with the memory of that awful manifestation before me? And the word of a Charteris is always sufficient. But I do think, Le Gautier, that you are pushing this thing too far.'

'Let the depth of my love excuse my impetuosity;' and again the words struck harshly on the listener's ears. 'Surely the excuse is a good one. I am leaving England shortly; and before I go, I must—nay, I will have an answer to the question which affects my happiness so deeply. It is only fair, only just that I should know my fate.'

Sir Geoffrey speculated feebly what he was to do with a man like this. 'But have a little patience; let me prepare her for your proposal.'

'Which you will promise to do, and put off day after day, as a man does who has an unpleasant task to perform. No, Sir Geoffrey; I do not wish to conduct my wooing second-hand. There is no time like the present; my

motto is "Now." I do not ask you to help me; but before I leave this house, it is my intention to speak to your daughter.'

In sheer desperation, not unmixed with a little irritation, Sir Geoffrey rang the bell, and desired the servant to conduct Le Gautier up-stairs. The thing must come sooner or later, he knew; and so long as he was not asked personally to interfere, he did not so much mind, though he was not unconscious of sundry twinges of conscience as his arbitrary visitor disappeared.

## RACING ROGUERIES.

To a man not infected with the disease, Turf-mania must appear the blindest of all infatuations. The gambler who trusts to the fall of the cards, arguing that in the natural fitness of things he is certain to be a winner some day, and spends all his time in calculating the doctrine of chances, is a rational person to the gull who, knowing what a mass of roguery leavens the Turf, will yet stake money, honour, and life upon its eventualities. Yet this is done every day, not only by greenhorns, but by men who are quite alive to the mysterious workings of the betting ring, who are fully aware that the ability of the horse or the jockey is the last factor to be taken into consideration; who can amuse you for hours with stories of the swindles practised by owners, trainers, jockeys, 'rings,' and who yet go on putting their money on the horse 'that must win'—and never wins—in utter defiance of their foregathered knowledge. The racing 'prophet' who is behind the scenes, who makes 'the turf' the business of his life, not only fools the readers of the newspaper to which he sells his vaticinations, but himself as well, and often returns from a race as penniless as the silly ones who pin their faith upon his oracular utterances. Even the bookmaker has his 'fancies,' upon which he stakes, and loses, the money that fools have put into his purse, with a blind confidence that is almost incredible.

A certain horse has acquitted himself well in his trial gallops; there is not one in the race can beat him; and *if* he were allowed to do his best, would undoubtedly be the winner. But, as Touchstone says, 'There is much virtue in an *if*.' In the first place, the owner may not intend him to win, and may have actually made arrangements for laying against his own horse. Or if the owner be 'straight,' the jockey may have been bribed to check the horse's speed as he nears the winning-post by some one whose interest it is that the horse shall not win. All these may work together, or each may have different interests in the event. And even should the animal be meant in all honesty to win, a stable lad for a five-pound note may secretly physic the horse, and good-bye the chances of the favourite on the morrow. Or some lurking ruffian in the pay of another owner or bookmaker may contrive to gain admission into the stable unknown to the animal's guardians, and

‘nobble’ for himself. But even after every form of knavery has been set aside, there are contingencies that still render the risks of backing horses enormous. The jockey may spend the night before the race in dissipation, and mount with swimming head and nerveless hands; or in his cups he may betray some secret of the stable that will give the advantage to a rival; or the horse himself may become sick, or be out of form, or stumble, or be thrown out by a cur running across the course, or other accidents easy of occurrence; and yet, knowing all this, men will madly risk large sums upon the supposition that no such *contretemps* will happen.

A few anecdotes, however, of undeniable authenticity will better illustrate the tricks of the Turf than would pages of reflections and generalisations.

About half a century ago, at Newmarket, several horses who stood high in the betting, at different times suddenly went off sick just before the race for which they were entered; some died, others recovered, but all were disabled for the time being, and favourites that a few hours previously outstripped every rival, would come straggling yards behind the field. Every one knew they had been ‘nobbled;’ but for a long time the perpetrator remained undiscovered; at last, however, a notorious scoundrel, one Dan Dawson, was caught red-handed poisoning the troughs. During the trial, it came out that he had made a regular trade of these nefarious practices, and it was more than suspected that not a few of the biggest men on the Turf were his employers. But although he was condemned to death, whether from the hope that some among his influential patrons would intercede for a reprieve, or from that hatred which certain men of his class have against ‘peaching,’ he never betrayed them, and remained silent to the end. The most minute precautions are taken to guard the racehorse from such dangers, yet the cunning or daring of his enemies frequently proves more than a match for the care of his owners.

In 1842, Lanercost was regarded as the certain victor for the Ascot Cup. While he was being conveyed to the course in a van, the grooms in charge stopped at an inn between Leatherhead and Sunninghill to refresh, leaving one to keep watch. Just after they had gone into the house, two sailors came out of it. ‘Hillo,’ cried one, ‘here’s Lanercost; let’s have a peep at him;’ and he sprang up on the side of the van, while his companion at the same time diverted the attention of the man on guard. A moment afterwards, the first jumped down again, and then the two disappeared into a copse: it was all



done so quickly that the groom had no time to interpose; and before he could summon his mates, the men were out of sight. When the race came on, instead of achieving the anticipated victory, poor Lanercost came in last. In the course of the ensuing month, he entirely changed colour, and was never fit to run again. There is no doubt that the pretended sailor had contrived to administer some powerful drug to the animal during the few seconds he hung over his box.

Somewhere about the same time, a horse named Marcus was the favourite for the St Leger. The day before the race, while he and some other horses were standing at the *Doncaster Arms*, an ill-looking fellow entered the kitchen of that tavern and seated himself beside a boiler from which the stable lads were every now and then drawing water for their charges. There was no one in the kitchen save a maid-servant, whom the stranger sent out to bring him a pot of beer. When she returned, the girl was going to fill her tea-kettle from the boiler, but the fellow stopped her by saying: 'I wouldn't take my tea-water from there if I was you, it looks so yellow and greasy.'

'All right; I'll get it outside,' she answered. When she came back the second time, the man had gone.

The next morning two horses were found dead in their stalls; while Marcus, who was just able to run, came in last, and also died during the day. Upon the bodies being opened, arsenic was found in their stomachs. The girl then remembered the incident of the loafer, who had no doubt poisoned the water in the copper; and had she been as stubborn as most of her kind, several human victims would have been added to the equine list. By the defeat of Marcus, the owner of a horse named Chorister won seven thousand pounds.

Sometimes the defeat of the favourite is brought about by less bold but more subtle means; and occasionally the tables are turned in a very unexpected manner, as in the following instance. For the Doncaster of 1824, Jerry—a horse belonging to a well-known sporting man named Gascoigne—was the favourite. A little before the event came off, however, George Payne, a noted Turfite, got 'the tip' from John Gully, the ex-prizefighter, that Jerry would not win; and the day before the race, these two worthies, doubtless well knowing *why*, laid six thousand against him. Gascoigne could not understand how it was that the more he backed his horse, which was in magnificent condition, the less it advanced in favour. He felt sure

there was a screw loose somewhere, but he could not tell in what direction to look for it. Two nights before the race, as he was taking a walk in the outskirts of Doncaster, he paused at a turnpike gate, and just at that moment a postchaise stopped to pay toll. By the light of the lamp which the toll-keeper held in his hand, Gascoigne observed the jockey who was to ride Jerry next day seated within, almost helplessly drunk, between two of the most notorious blacklegs of the time. In a moment he saw it all. Hurrying away, lest he should be recognised, he went back to his hotel, and set about concocting measures to counteract the plot that he perceived had been formed against him. Without making known his discovery to any one, he secured the services of another jockey, bound the man down to silence; and at the last moment, just as the traitor was going to mount, his substitute slipped into the saddle, and won the race, to the discomfiture and well-merited loss of the conspirators, who had betted all they possessed upon the event.

Men called ‘Touts’ are employed by bookmakers and others to watch racehorses at exercise and report upon their condition; these spies are abhorred by trainers and owners, and have to pursue their espionage under many difficulties, sometimes lying in a dry or a damp ditch, or a hole covered over with brambles, or on the roof of a stable, to be ready to witness the morning gallop. When detected, they do not often escape under a horsewhipping or a ducking. On one bitterly cold night, a fellow had crawled upon the roof of a stall to listen if the favourite had a cough. Aware of his presence, though pretending to be ignorant of it, the trainer ordered the stable boys to throw up pails of water upon the spot where he was ensconced until the very clothes froze upon the poor wretch’s back; but he had the consolation of hearing the horse stabled beneath cough several times, and next morning the odds were heavy against the favourite. Unfortunately for the rogues, however, the favourite on the previous night had been moved into another stable, and a horse with a cough had been substituted, to deceive the tout, with the result that those who ventured their money on his information, lost.

A much cleverer ruse was the following. An owner named Wilson was about to try a two-year-old colt. ‘We shall be watched, and his white right fore-leg will be sure to be noticed,’ remarked the trainer.—‘Leave that to me,’ said Mr Wilson. Next morning, he was at the stable at daybreak, and

with some black paint soon changed the colour of the leg; while a brush dipped in white transferred the distinguishing mark to a far inferior horse, which showed but poorly beside the other. The tout on the watch naturally took one for the other, and reported accordingly. The next day, a certain nobleman gave fifteen hundred for the falsified animal, which was worth about four.

We have purposely omitted the more celebrated Turf swindles, such as the 'Running Rein' fraud, and others that made a sensation in their day, confining ourselves to the less known affairs, which were not found out until reparation to the victims was impossible, our principal desire being to make clear to 'the outsiders' the enormous odds against which they stake their money.

Those who are not behind the scenes may suppose that the bookmakers (pencillers) and the 'knowing ones' generally, enjoy a perfect immunity from the perils and dangers, pitfalls and temptations, of horseracing; but that is not the case. Not unfrequently they walk blindly into the trap they set for others; the biter is frequently bitten; and many an ingenious fraud has been put upon the 'pencillers' by outside betting-men, as the two following stories will show. For obvious reasons, all data are suppressed, but the truth of the anecdotes can be vouched for.

One day a City man, who was given to betting, and whom we shall call A, received a visit from a friend addicted to the same weakness, who shall be designated B. Locking the room door and sinking his voice to a whisper, B announced that he had made a wonderful discovery by which betting could be reduced to a system of all prizes and no blanks, and consequently a fortune very quickly realised. 'Now is your chance,' he said, 'if you like to join me. I shall give no explanation of the method; come and see for yourself.'

An appointment was made for the next morning, the date of the X races, at the Z (betting) Club.

'Have you anything on this race?' was the first inquiry made by B as A came into the room.

The answer was in the negative.

‘Now, listen to me,’ said B, drawing him into a corner, for the place, as usual at such times, was crowded with betting-men; ‘the final list for the twelve o’clock race will be telegraphed here in a few minutes.’ (The Z, it need scarcely be said, had its private tape.) ‘Lay all the money you like, at any odds, upon the horse I shall select, and I will guarantee that it shall be the winner. But mind, you must not lose a second after I have given you the hint. Go to the nearest bookmaker in the room and make your bet on the instant.’

A minute or two afterwards, the electric bell gave the signal, and there was a general rush to the machine. B was one of the first to scan the list: there were five runners. He passed his finger down the names until he paused almost imperceptibly upon Y, and looked at his companion, who, although it was the very last horse he would have thought of backing, boldly called out: ‘I’ll take the odds against Y.’

Y being a rank outsider, a bookmaker laid the odds on the instant. One minute afterwards came the announcement that Y was the winner.

After they left the club together, B unfolded the mystery. ‘When the list of runners was telegraphed,’ he said, ‘the race was already won.’

‘But how could that be?’ asked A. ‘The race was run at twelve, and the time on the telegram was three minutes to twelve.’

‘The time was falsified,’ was the reply. ‘The message was not wired until past the hour, nor until the winner was declared.’

‘And how could you fix upon the right one?’ demanded A.

‘There was the minutest dash on the tape against the name of the winner, only noticeable by one in the secret. You see, the clerks are in the pay of an Association. There are three or four other clubs beside this where we get the telegrams in the same manner, so that we vary our times. Here, for instance, we put upon the twelve o’clock race; at another, upon the one; at a third, upon the two, and so on.’

We may add that the fraud was ultimately discovered, and the clerks who worked it severely punished.

The next trick we shall relate could not be practised now, in consequence of an alteration in the Turf customs. It was worked in this fashion by two

confederates. Let us suppose it to be the Lewes races. One of the two goes down to Lewes on the previous day, and by the last post sends a letter addressed *in pencil* and unsealed to his brother-rogue in London. Inside the envelope is a note addressed to a bookmaker, simply containing the words, 'Please back \_\_\_\_ for so much.—Yours truly, JONES'—a blank being left for the horse's name. This missive arrives in town by the morning post, and the instant the race is run the name of the winner is telegraphed to rogue number two, who then inserts the name of the horse, rubs out his own name and address from the envelope, writes that of the bookmaker instead, and seals it up. Everything is now perfect in appearance: there are the Lewes postmark of the previous night, the London of the morning, and the seal untampered with. We need scarcely say that the handwriting appears to be the same, and, according to the rules of racing at that time, if a letter be delayed in transmission through the post, the bookmaker is still made answerable for its contents.

And now, how is it to be got into his hands without exciting suspicion? There are several ways of doing this: sometimes he may be at the club, and then the letter is dropped into the letter-box; but the favourite dodge is to dress up a man as a postman, with bag and a bundle of letters in his hand, who will deliver it at the victim's office; or the confederate will watch for the real postman, walk behind him, drop the letter on the pavement, and then call out to the carrier: 'Hillo, you've dropped one of your letters.'

The man will pick it up, and, being almost certain to have others addressed to the same person, innocently play the rogue's game. As to the bookmaker, all he can do is to write a letter of complaint to St Martin's-le-Grand and pay the money.

You cannot touch pitch without being defiled, or play with edged tools without being cut, says the old proverb; and you cannot associate with rogues and play the rogue without occasionally being swindled yourself.

# MISS MASTERMAN'S DISCOVERY.

## IN TWO CHAPTERS.—CHAP. II.

SINCE she left the rectory, she had had two letters from Lady O'Leary, a passage in the second having made a powerful impression upon her: 'Since your departure, my dear Phœbe, I have had leisure for much reflection on the subject of your frightful discovery; and after considerable cogitation, I have arrived at the conclusion that it is certainly your bounden duty to acquaint the bishop with the conduct of Mr Draycott, and to do so at once before you return to Sunnydale. I should advise you to write and inclose that abandoned widow's note. I fancy that we are not the only ones who are beginning to see through this sanctimonious villain of a rector. I observed last Sunday that several of the congregation, amongst them Lady Conyers and General Scott and his family, who always stay for a chat with the Draycotts after service, left the church as quickly as possible, as if to avoid speaking to any of the family. Mrs Penrose was not at church; no doubt she had her reasons for staying away, though I heard from Miss Jones that it was given out that it was a bad headache that kept her at home.'

From Lady O'Leary's statement, it was not clear if Mrs Penrose's headache had been publicly announced in church or not; and the worthy lady had also omitted to mention that it was entirely owing to her own hints and innuendoes, industriously dropped here and there, accompanied by significant looks of unutterable meaning, that the mind of the parish was being considerably exercised with grave doubts as to Mr Draycott's moral character. The letter went on to say that invitations had been issued for a large evening party at the rectory on the following Thursday. Lady O'Leary strongly urged Miss Masterman so to time her return as to be present at it, adding: 'I intend to go, as I feel it my duty to neglect no opportunity of collecting evidence which may serve to deliver our hearths and homes from the contaminating presence of the shameless Draycott!'

On reading this, Miss Masterman considered that there was no further proof wanting of the enormity of the rector's guilt. Another suspicious

circumstance was, that she had received no invitation, and in three days the party would take place. She therefore felt convinced that the rector, dreading lest her keen eye should detect more than would be noticed by the shallow members of his own family, had made some excuse to prevent Mrs Draycott from bidding her to the festivity; consequently, resolving to hesitate no longer, she sat down and indited the following letter:

*To the Right Rev. the Lord Bishop of —.*

MY LORD—I venture, as a temporary resident in the parish of Sunnydale, to call to your lordship's notice some heinous irregularities in the conduct of the Rev. Stephen Draycott, rector of that parish. I should indeed blush to record the details of his guilt in any words of mine; but the inclosed note, addressed to him by a person who calls herself 'Mrs Penrose,' will, I think, speak for itself. The individual whom I allude to is, I have every reason to fear, an astute adventuress; and should your Lordship think it worth while to make further inquiries respecting her, I have no doubt that sufficient evidence will speedily be found to substantiate my statements in every respect.—I have the honour to be, My Lord, Your Lordship's most obedient humble servant,

(MISS) PHÆBE MASTERMAN.

Miss Masterman next wrote a letter to the unconscious Mrs Draycott, fixing the following Friday for her return, at the same time fully intending to make some excuse for arriving unexpectedly on Thursday afternoon instead, so as to be in time for the party in the evening. She then sent a few lines to Lady O'Leary acquainting her with all she had done; and after seeing her letters posted, she congratulated herself on the courage and resolution with which she had carried out what she believed to be a duty to society.

On Thursday, Miss Masterman left Bradborough early in the morning, having so arranged her journey that she would arrive at Sunnydale about six, which, as she calculated, would give her time to unpack and dress for the evening. But, by an unfortunate chance, it happened that as the train by which she travelled during the first part of her journey was delayed, it would be quite impossible to be at the rectory much before eleven o'clock P.M. Even Miss Masterman felt that that would be too late an hour at which to arrive unexpectedly; so she made up her mind that her only course would

be to go to the village inn for the night, her one consolation being, that Lady O'Leary would be sure to give her a full and particular account of all that occurred at the rectory.

The alteration in her arrangements was most annoying to Miss Masterman, who, like many other rich people, if she made a plan, expected, as a matter of course, that it should be rigidly adhered to. During four hours which she had to wait at a junction, she sat and brooded over her grievances, waxing more and more grim as she did so. To add to her irritation, the rain began to come down in torrents; and the cold and draughty station was made additionally comfortless by the damp air which came in through every door and window, and penetrated to every bone in Miss Masterman's body.

At length, however, the dreary journey came to an end; and on reaching her destination, she took a fly, and ordered the man to drive her to the only decent inn that Sunnydale could boast. By this time it was past eleven o'clock. The rain had ceased, and the moon was shining brightly, throwing streams of silvery light on all around, and bringing every object into unusual prominence. In order to reach the inn, it was necessary to pass Fern Lodge, the pretty cottage residence of Mrs Penrose. Fancying she heard voices, Miss Masterman leaned forward and looked out of the window. What was her horror and amazement to see Mr Draycott gallantly escorting Mrs Penrose to her door! There was no mistaking the rector's tall figure and dignified deportment. But the widow! Dressed in what appeared to be an elegant costume, her bare arms and neck, plainly visible through her black lace shawl, were gleaming with diamonds! But even this was not all! The bright moonlight falling on her upturned face as she smiled upon Mr Draycott, plainly revealed powder and rouge! Slowly the pair advanced towards the house, and as a turn in the road hid them from sight, Mr Draycott was bending over his companion, apparently engaged in earnest conversation.

Miss Masterman sank back in the fly in the greatest agitation. Her worst suspicions were now confirmed! and by the time she arrived at the inn, she felt fairly exhausted with excitement. Miss Masterman at once requested to be shown to her room; and during the greater part of the night she lay awake, thinking over the startling discoveries she had made and their probable results. On one point she had quite made up her mind—that nothing would induce her to remain any longer under the same roof with the



rector. So she arranged with the hostess of the *Sunnydale Arms* that she would stay there for a week—to await events. At an early hour she called upon Lady O’Leary; but, to her great disappointment, she found that lady confined to her room with such a severe attack of gout, that she had been unable to be present at the rectory on the previous evening. The invalid listened with greedy interest to Miss Masterman’s revelations, and for the moment she forgot the pain she was enduring in the delight of hearing about Mrs Penrose’s rouge, and especially the diamonds, which were ‘confirmation strong,’ if any were needed, of the words in the fatal letter. On her side, Lady O’Leary had little to tell Miss Masterman, except that two days ago she had seen Magdalen Draycott, who told her that they only expected about half the number they had asked to the party, as so many had refused. The girl had also said that her mother was a good deal worried about it; from which Lady O’Leary concluded that things were coming to a crisis, and that people were beginning to see the unprincipled Draycott in his true colours. The interview between the two ladies was terminated by a paroxysm of agony which seized upon the invalid, and completely incapacitated her for further conversation.

Miss Masterman returned to the inn for lunch, and then prepared for her momentous visit to the rectory; for she had resolved to beard the lion in his den, and to denounce him in the presence of his family as a hypocrite. On arriving at the rectory, she was told by the servant who appeared in answer to her imperious knock, that the rector was at that time engaged with the churchwardens and others on parish business, and could not be interrupted.

‘My business will not admit of delay,’ replied Miss Masterman. ‘I must insist upon seeing the rector at once.’ Then, as the servant endeavoured to expostulate—‘No words!’ continued the spinster; ‘conduct me to him at once.’

The servant then led the way, though with evident reluctance, and throwing open the drawing-room door, announced Miss Masterman.

Bristling with conscious virtue, her tall form drawn up to its fullest height, she intrepidly advanced, seeming to breathe out threatenings and slaughter in her progress, and her whole appearance formidable to the last degree.

The dining-room was full of people, who were seated round the long table, at the head of which presided the rector. The two churchwardens were

seated near him. The rest of the party included Mrs Draycott, Lady Conyers, General Scott, and many of the leading residents of Sunnydale, who had met to discuss some necessary alterations in the hours of the church services. At sight of Miss Masterman, a dead silence fell upon the assembly. Nothing daunted, she advanced to Mrs Draycott, and held out her hand; but, to her surprise, she was repulsed. She was then addressed by the rector, who, rising from his chair, said in dignified accents: 'If you wish to speak to me, Miss Masterman, I will come to you presently in the study. At present, I am engaged, as you see, with my friends.'

'I can perfectly understand your motives in wishing to speak to me without witnesses, Mr Draycott,' replied she; 'but you shall not escape so easily. What I have to say shall be said here, in the hearing of your wife, and of the friends whom you have so grossly deceived.'

'I spoke for your own sake, madam, not mine,' said the rector, as he turned pale with anger. 'But since you insist upon it, pray, let my friends hear what excuse you have to offer for this uncalled-for intrusion.'

'I wish to acquaint them with your real character,' answered Miss Masterman firmly. 'You know that you are an unprincipled man and a profligate.'

At these audacious words, all the company rose to their feet, with the exception of Mr Sheldon, the rector's churchwarden, a young and rising solicitor, who—his professional instincts instantly on the alert—scented legal proceedings, and began quickly and silently to take notes of all that passed. The other churchwarden, Mr Blare, a little puffy, red-faced man, with a temper that was the terror of all the naughty boys in the parish, after vainly trying to express his wrath articulately, sank back into his chair again gasping and snorting, till his face assumed an apoplectic hue that was truly alarming. The rest of the assembly loudly expressed their indignation at Miss Masterman's extraordinary allegations; when above the din rang out the rector's clear and penetrating voice. 'My friends,' he cried, 'will you be seated, and listen to me?' Then, as they obeyed in silence, he turned to the furious woman before him, and continued: 'May I ask, Miss Masterman, by what right you abstracted a letter from my study, and then took the unwarrantable liberty of sending it to the bishop?'

‘I wished to open the bishop’s eyes to your real character,’ replied Miss Masterman. ‘I read that letter by the merest accident, and I felt that it was only right that others should be undeceived as well as myself.’

‘And are you aware,’ demanded Mr Draycott sternly, ‘that you have rendered yourself liable to an action for libel?’

‘Certainly not,’ answered Miss Masterman, ‘for I have only spoken the truth. It is of no use to try and bully, Mr Draycott; your character has now been discovered.’

At this crisis, Miss Masterman was interrupted by an angry snort from Mr Blare, who, after making another futile attempt to express himself coherently, subsided into a violent fit of coughing, after which, he contented himself with giving vent to a short jeering laugh whenever Miss Masterman spoke, in a manner that irritated that lady almost beyond endurance.

‘Perhaps, before you indulge in any more strong language, you will be good enough to listen to a few words of explanation,’ proceeded the rector. ‘The letter which you purloined from my study referred merely to some theatricals. My wife had written a little play in which Mrs Penrose was to take part; the play was to be acted last night at a party in this house, which had been purposely kept a secret from you on account of your known dislike of all theatrical entertainments. The articles alluded to in Mrs Penrose’s letter to me were required by her for the part she was to play. Had you mentioned the matter to me or to any member of my family, you would have heard the truth, and spared yourself and us much unnecessary pain.’

‘Then,’ gasped Miss Masterman, ‘when I saw you and Mrs Penrose at eleven o’clock last night’——

‘I was escorting her home, after her kindness in helping us,’ replied Mr Draycott. Then, as his voice trembled with suppressed anger, he continued: ‘I have been this morning, thanks to your impertinent interference, subjected to a severe cross-examination by my bishop; and though I trust he is now convinced of the falsehood of your allegations, I have been put in a most painful position. Owing to you and Lady O’Leary—who has not scrupled to spread scandalous reports about me in my own parish—I have been cut by some of my most valued friends; and if I refrain from

prosecuting you both for libel, it is only on condition that you offer a full and ample apology for your most wicked and uncalled-for assertions.'

As Miss Masterman heard these words, she felt ready to sink through the ground, for she at once saw the folly and wickedness of her conduct in its true light. All her assurance deserted her, and she feebly tried to falter out a few words of regret; but the rector sternly interrupted her. 'That is not sufficient, Miss Masterman,' said he. 'I must trouble you to write at once to the bishop, and also to send a paragraph to the local papers, to retract every word that you and Lady O'Leary have said against my character. Should you, or she, refuse to do me this justice, I shall immediately commence proceedings against you both!'

Here the solicitor interposed with: 'I am in a position to warn Miss Masterman that should Mr Draycott determine to institute proceedings for libel, the damages in this case might be excessive.'

Baffled, confounded, and for the first time in her life completely cowed, Miss Masterman looked helplessly around her, and had the mortification of seeing Lady Conyers, General Scott, those rich and influential members of the congregation, whose friendship she had so sedulously cultivated, turn their backs upon her in utter contempt, as she passed down the room; even kind Mrs Draycott averted her eyes from her; and her equanimity was by no means restored when, on reaching the door, she found that it had been left partially open, and that the whole of the preceding conversation had been overheard by Master Hubert, who was now turning somersaults in the hall, as Miss Masterman more than suspected, in celebration of her own discomfiture.

It is scarcely necessary to add that Miss Masterman and her friend were only too thankful to accept the rector's terms, and so escape the just penalty of their conduct; and whenever, after this, Miss Masterman felt inclined to give too free license to her tongue, the rising temptation was instantly subdued by the recollection of the mischief once wrought by that unruly member during her summer holiday in the parish of Sunnydale.

## PHOTOGRAPHIC STAR-CHARTING.

It is now some years since photography was first called to the assistance of the astronomer, and the results which have been achieved show that it will play a still more important part in the future. A description of all its advantages would carry us far beyond the limits of the present article; but we mention four, as they are necessary to the understanding of the subject.

The power which the sensitive film possesses of recording the appearance of a bright object to whose light it has been exposed for only a minute fraction of a second, has enabled us to obtain pictures of the sun that are much more accurate than ordinary drawings. The camera, moreover, has the faculty of seeing a great deal in a very short space of time. If we confine our attention to a small area, a very few moments suffice to show us all that is to be seen by the naked eye; persistent looking for half an hour would only tire our eyes without enabling us to see anything at first invisible. It is different with the camera; the longer the light is permitted to fall on the plate, the more details do we find in the resulting picture. The fact that some rays are more effective (photographically) than others has enabled Dr Huggins to photograph, in full sunlight, that extremely faint solar appendage, the corona, which is visible to the eye only when the intense light of the sun is hidden as during a total eclipse.

The latest demand which has been made upon the astronomer's new assistant is no less than a great atlas of all the stars down to those of the fifteenth magnitude. The magnificent idea of photographing this immense number of stars—probably about twenty millions—is due to the officials of the Paris Observatory. The instrument which Messrs Paul and Prosper Henry have constructed for this research may be described roughly as two telescopes side by side and moving together. One of these, having a specially designed object-glass, carries the sensitive plate for the reception of the image. The arrangement is provided with a clockwork motion, in order that, during the time of exposure, the situation of each star's image may not alter; but as clockwork, however carefully made, is not infallible, an observer, looking through the second telescope, nips in the bud, so to

speak, any tendency to aberration. Since the little spots that frequently occur on the photographic plates may be mistaken for stars, and so serve to swell future lists of 'variables,' each plate is exposed three times, and each star is therefore represented by three marks. The alteration in the position of the plate between each of the three exposures is so slight, that it requires a microscope to show that the dots are triple. With this splendid apparatus, only one two-hundredth of a second is necessary for the recording of the position of first-magnitude stars. Those of the sixth magnitude, which can only be perceived with the naked eye on a very dark night, require only half a second. The faintest which can be seen through the telescope, those of about the fourteenth magnitude, take three minutes to make an impression. But although the human eye is not sensitive enough to go any farther than this, stars of the fifteenth and even the sixteenth magnitude can be made to appear on the plate, if the exposure be sufficiently prolonged. In the latter case, an hour and a half is necessary.

In one of Messrs Henry's charts, about five thousand stars were counted. The construction of such a chart by the ordinary method of measurement would have taken many months; now it only takes three hours. Thus the preparation of a set of maps such as Messrs Henry suggest would occupy less time than the charting of one-hundredth part of the number of stars by ordinary methods. It has been calculated that if the work be divided among twelve observatories, five hundred and ten photographs would be required from each; and making every allowance, ten years would probably see the completion of the most elaborate survey of the whole heavens ever undertaken. This may seem a long time; but we must remember that Argelander's great charts of the northern hemisphere, which contained only three hundred and twenty-four thousand stars, occupied seven years of observatory work alone!

The importance of obtaining a permanent record of the present positions of twenty million stars cannot be overestimated. We find that if old measurements, such as those of Ptolemy, Copernicus, Tycho Brahe, and others, are to be trusted, very great changes must have taken place in the heavens. But are they to be trusted? The differences between their observations and ours must in many cases be attributed to the roughness of their instruments; but some cannot be altogether explained thus. As, however, we do not know where actual change ends and faulty

measurement begins, no very definite knowledge can be derived from the comparison. A photograph of some part of the heavens by Cassini—what an invaluable legacy it would have been! With such a survey as Messrs Henry propose, future astronomers will be able not only to be sure of the existence of changes, but also to measure their extent. But the astronomers of the future will not be the only gainers. During an hour, a planet moves quite an appreciable distance; it will therefore appear on the plate as a short line instead of a point. Thus, one of the first results will probably be a considerable accession to the numbers of the minor planets which circulate between Mars and Jupiter. Who knows that the transneptunian planet itself will not be found in this way? Besides this very obvious advantage, these charts will be of the greatest use in the study of the form and constitution of the stellar universe. It is only by the employment of such charts that we can arrive at a proper understanding of star arrangement. The methods of star-gauging which Sir William Herschel employed for this purpose failed to give any satisfactory account of the form of the Milky-way in space. His first method was to point his large telescope in various directions successively, counting the number of stars visible in the field each time. He argued that if the stars were scattered with approximate uniformity throughout the galaxy, then the more he counted in a unit of area, the farther must it extend in that direction. On this assumption, he calculated that the depth of the Milky-way was eighty times the distance of the first-magnitude stars. Sir John Herschel, by precisely the same method, found the proportion to be seven hundred and fifty instead of eighty! This discrepancy alone gives some idea of the untrustworthiness of the method; and there are many other arguments against it, into which we have not space to enter.

Sir William's second method, although sometimes confounded with his first, was in reality quite different from it. Instead of counting the number of points of light seen with the same telescope in equal small areas in various parts of the Milky-way, he now attempted to estimate the depth by noting the telescopic power necessary to 'resolve' the nebulous places into crowds of separate stars. When we examine the galaxy with the naked eye, it appears to be simply a cloud of misty light. A small telescope, however, suffices to show that it is made up of stars; but in most parts the background still seems nebulous. A stronger telescope entirely clears up and resolves some of these nebulous portions, while other parts require a still stronger power, and so on. In this way, then, assuming that the more difficult a misty

part of the heavens was to resolve, the farther off the stars composing that misty part were, he attempted to gauge the star depths. It now appears that when he thought he was penetrating space farther and farther with telescopes of gradually increasing power, he was in reality only resolving masses of (smaller) stars situated at about the same average distance as the larger bodies which had been already distinguished with a feebler power, and which he had therefore assumed to be nearer. As a well-known writer says: 'In each case where Herschel had assumed that he was penetrating farther and farther into space, he was only analysing more and more scrutinisingly a complex cloud of stars.' It is interesting to notice in this connection that one still sees Herschel's so-called split-grindstone theory (which was based on observations made by the first method) quoted and illustrated in many text-books, although he renounced it himself; and it is perfectly obvious to any one who has considered the question in the light of recent researches, that that theory is totally untenable.

The charting method gives a very different account of the constitution of the universe. Investigation in this direction has shown that the Milky-way, far from being an affair of great depth in proportion to its distance from us, is really what it seems, an immense irregular stream or belt composed of stars of all sizes. Much information has been extracted from Argelander's great charts; but the photographic charts that will contain sixty or seventy times as many stars will be still more useful. If the idea is taken up as enthusiastically as it ought to be, and if our government, so niggardly in matters scientific, can be induced to follow the enlightened example of the Emperor of Brazil, and provide our observers with proper instruments, there is no reason why this great atlas should not be an accomplished fact in a few years.



## DAVID'S SON SOLOMON.

MR DAVID MOSES, who is now dead, was a jeweller and pawnbroker in Wych Street. He kept a very good show of jewelry in the front window of his establishment, and was never known to complain as to trade being unsatisfactory in the line of watches and precious stones and electro-plate. But Mr Moses made much more money by his pawnbroking than by his jeweller's shop, and still more by discounting bills at cent. per cent., than by either of the two businesses which he ostensibly followed. The bill-discounting, which was also accompanied by money-lending at stiff rates, was not done at the shop in Wych Street, but at an office in the neighbourhood of Lombard Street. The office was handsomely fitted up; the shop was rather second-hand in appearance, and filled with odds and ends which had never been redeemed from pawn. At the shop, Mr Moses rarely showed himself, for he had a valuable assistant in the shape of his deceased wife's sister, Miss Rachel Levi, who managed the pawnbroking and jewelry business with a regard to the main point that would have done credit to Shylock. The aptitude of this elderly Jewess left Mr Moses plenty of time to attend to the office in the neighbourhood of Lombard Street. He was not Mr David Moses there; that cognomen was painted in faded gilt letters above the Wych Street shop; but the office bore the name of 'Mr Alfred Morris,' which title seemed more in accordance with the character of the clients who came thither to borrow on the strength of their aristocratic names or connections, or to transact business connected with what is technically termed a 'bit of stiff.' Anybody who was anybody could always get a 'bit of stiff' from Mr Alfred Morris, provided he had no objection to pay a handsome rate of interest, and allow a fair margin for commission and charges and other little incidental expenses. Many of Mr Alfred Morris's clients knew his real name to be David Moses, and were aware of the Wych Street business, where, indeed, some of them had property lying in pledge. These, however, were old customers, and could be trusted; to all new ones and to the outside world, Moses was Mr Alfred Morris.

In appearance, the old man was eminently Hebraic. He had a hooked nose, and very curly white hair; he spoke with a nasal accent, and called middle-

aged men 'ma tear.' As regards his business character, he was Shylockish. He wanted, and took good care to get, his pound of flesh, and an ounce or two over. He never blushed to lend you fifty pounds on a hundred pounds acceptance, or seemed to think it out of the way to deduct five pounds from the fifty for 'present expenses.' By his orders, the poor folk who came on Monday morning to put the Sunday wearing apparel into pawn till the following Saturday evening were screwed down to the fraction of a penny; while the timid vendor of second-hand jewelry or old gold was browbeaten to such an extent that he or she gradually came to the opinion that the goods were really worth no more than Miss Rachel Levi represented, and thankfully accepted the price which that estimable lady offered. It was Mr Moses' idea of business to be hard and sharp and to look out for number one.

There was, however, in the heart of Moses one very soft spot. It may seem incredible that he who sucked the very lifeblood from young and foolish scions of noble houses, or made no difficulty in getting hold of the substance of widows and orphans, should have been capable of affection. But Moses was capable of a great deal of affection, and this soft spot was all affection. It is a pity that we should have to say the affection was lavished on a worthless object; for Mr Solomon Moses, the only son and child of the old money-lender, and whom the old man loved as well and as dotingly as his riches, was a thoroughly bad young scoundrel. When David Moses was sixty, his son Solomon was twenty-three, and schooled in vice and debauchery.

The senior Moses' plans with regard to his boy were from the boy's very birth of the high and mighty kind. He intended first of all that the little Solomon should be a 'shentleman,' and have nothing to do with the shop in Wych Street. He should, on attaining his majority, be provided with unlimited pocket-money and told to 'go the pace.' Perhaps, thought Mr David Moses, some of the young swells whom he was always having dealings with would take Solomon up and initiate him into the mysteries of society. When, therefore, Solomon came to his twenty-first birthday, Mr Moses took expensive chambers for him in the West, placed a handsome sum with a banker at his son's credit, and told the young man that nothing would please him better than to know that his boy was living the life of a gentleman. You may be quite certain that Mr Solomon Moses was not slow

to take advantage of his father's kindness. His ideas of a gentlemanly life were somewhat hazy, but they were decided enough upon the subject of clothes of the fastest and loudest cut and style, of billiards and unlimited card-games, of gambling and prizefights, and of disreputable companions. He 'went the pace' splendidly; and Mr David Moses liked it, and thought his son a fine, lively young gentleman indeed.

When Solomon was twenty-three, he was as villainous a scamp as one could find in all London. The money he wasted would have supported a dozen ordinary families in comfort, yet he had twice persuaded his father to double his allowance. The old man was beginning to fear his son, and readily acceded to any request for money which Solomon made. Once or twice a shadow of suspicion had crossed his mind that Solomon was not the brilliant result he had hoped for. The younger Mr Moses, for instance, had not gained the entrée to society which it had been his father's aim he should secure. He had not made the acquaintance of the aristocracy, nor did he seem likely to contract a brilliant marriage with a peer's daughter; and the only comfort old David had was the thought that these things took time.

One hot day in the summer of 1883, Solomon called a hansom, and was driven to his father's office near Lombard Street. He found 'Mr Alfred Morris' in and free, and forthwith made known his wishes, which ran in the direction of the sum of one thousand pounds. Old David stared.

'But, ma tear poy, I haven't so much moneys about me!' he objected. 'And pesides, ma tear, I gave you your money for the quarter on'y last week. What may you require the moneys for?'

'Betting heavy, and lost,' said young Solomon briefly.

'Petting! O my poy, that's pad—that's pad! And lost too—that's worse! I tolt you not to pet unless you was certain of winning, Solomon, ma tear. Oh, to think that you are making the peautiful moneys fly away like that!' And then Mr David Moses plucked up spirit, and gave his worthy son a real good lecture on the evil of wasting money. Solomon listened impatiently, and again repeated his request for a thousand pounds. And he got it—as he knew he would. Then he went away and called another cab, and prepared to be driven back to his elegant rooms. As he was piloted up the Strand, it occurred to him that he would call in at Wych Street and see Aunt Rachel; so he stopped his cab, and went into the jeweller's shop, and was welcomed

by the old Jewess in the back-parlour. The worthy lady was polishing up some diamonds, and Solomon's eyes wandered over the precious baubles covetously.

'Anything very valuable there, auntie?' he asked presently.

'No, Solomon dear; nothing—nothing. The big diamond there is pretty well. It is worth two thousand pounds.'

'Two thousand, eh?' said young Mr Moses. 'Very fair that, ain't it?'

'Well, your father lent one thousand on it—or rather, I did.'

'Never redeemed?'

'No.'

Solomon took up the glittering stone and looked it carefully over. It was set in a massive ring, very plainly made, and with two or three distinctive marks inside the hoop. 'And you're asking two thousand for this, auntie?'

'Yes, my dear, that's the price. I shall put him in the window in a week or so.'

Solomon went home soon after that. His first proceeding, when he got out of his father's shop, was to write down in his pocket-book a very accurate description of the big diamond and its ring. A very clever and equally rascally plan was forming itself in his brain. By the time he reached Trafalgar Square, his plan was complete.

During the next week, more than one person stopped to gaze at the great diamond flashing in Moses' shop-window. Its price was not upon it; but it was evident from its size that it was of tremendous value. Passers-by speculated on the probable amount, and wondered when the thing would find a purchaser. About eleven o'clock on the first day of its exposure, a middle-aged gentleman, sauntering leisurely up Wych Street from Booksellers' Row, stopped in front of Moses' shop, and looked for some minutes at the contents of the window. He was a good-looking man, well dressed in a quiet, unostentatious fashion; evidently a man of substance and position. He was turning away, when his eye fell on the great diamond. He looked at it a second, and then opened the shop-door and walked in. A red-headed boy of distinct Hebraic extraction was yawning behind the counter.

‘What is the price of the large diamond in your window?’ asked the solid-looking gentleman.

The red-headed youth didn’t know, but would find out. He disappeared for a moment, and came back followed by Miss Rachel, who looked narrowly at the man who dared to ask the price of so large a stone. The gentleman bowed courteously to Miss Rachel, and repeated his question.

‘Two thousand pounds,’ replied Miss Rachel.

‘Ah! A large price. May I see it?’

Miss Rachel acquiesced, and took the diamond ring from its case in the window. The stranger looked it carefully over, examined every mark with a sharp eye, and finally returned it to the old Jewess.

‘I will purchase that ring, madam,’ he said. ‘Be good enough to put it aside for me until to-morrow morning, when I will call and pay for it. I have been in search of such a stone for some time.’

Miss Rachel Levi was delighted. So, she was sure, would Mr David Moses be. She carefully locked up the ring in a big safe, and the stranger went his way with many bows on either side.

Precisely at eleven o’clock the following morning the customer called. He was accompanied by a dapper little man, whom Miss Rachel recognised as one of Mr Attenborough’s principal assistants.

‘Good-morning, madam,’ said the stranger. ‘Here I am, you see, and here is the price of the ring—two Bank of England notes of one thousand pounds each. I think that is correct?’

Yes, that was correct; and Miss Rachel unlocked the safe and handed the ring over to the customer, who had laid his two one-thousand-pound notes on the counter before her. She placed the notes in the safe, looking them over with an experienced eye, to see that they were all right as regarded genuineness. The stranger received his ring, and turned to the man accompanying him.

‘I brought this gentleman with me,’ he said to Miss Rachel, ‘just to tell me his opinion of the stone.—Very fine one, is it not, Mr Jones?’ He passed the ring to the man as he spoke, and began to talk to Miss Rachel about the weather.

The man named Jones looked with attentive eye at the glittering thing in his hand. He examined the gold setting and seemed satisfied, and then looked at the enormous stone. Suddenly he uttered an exclamation which made Miss Rachel and the customer look round sharply. Mr Jones took a little peculiar-looking glass from his pocket and gazed at the diamond suspiciously. He said 'Ah!' very emphatically, and threw the ring on the counter.

'How much did you give, sir?' he asked of the customer, whose attention was now thoroughly aroused.

'Two thousand pounds.'

'Humph! Worth next to nothing. The gold's very good; the diamond's first-class paste!'

Miss Rachel uttered a faint scream as the customer turned to her. 'What explanation can you give of this, madam?' he asked.

The poor woman was dumb-stricken. She knew not what to say.

'Where did you get the ring, Miss Levi?' asked Mr Jones. 'Perhaps you've been imposed upon.'

'It was pledged with my brother David,' said Miss Rachel. 'O dear me, gentlemen, I can't think how it is! It must be an imposition.'

'Well, at anyrate, *I* can't be imposed upon,' said the stranger. 'So I'll thank you for my notes, madam; and there is your paste ring.—Dear me, what an escape I've had! I'm much obliged to you, Mr Jones, for your penetration.'

'Oh,' said Mr Jones, 'that's nothing! What puzzles me is that Moses, who is very sharp, should have been swindled, as he must have been. And then Miss Levi here is a regular authority on stones.'

By this time poor Rachel had handed over the notes, and was regarding the false ring with a very disconsolate face. She was thinking what David would have to say on his return home.

The stranger pressed something in the way of remuneration on Mr Jones and went away.

Jones stayed a minute or two longer and talked the matter over with Miss Rachel. It was his idea that old Moses had had a duplicate made of the big

diamond for some purpose of his own, and that he had substituted the shadow for the substance. He suggested this to Miss Rachel, who was thereby a little comforted.

But Mr Jones' suspicion was wrong, as Miss Rachel quickly found on her brother's home-coming. She told him the story immediately he appeared, and the old man went nearly mad. He yelled for the ring to be brought him. Once in his hands, he literally shrieked with horror. 'It isn't the tiamont at all!' he cried. 'Mine was not paste, as this is. It's some conjuring trick, woman!' And he fell to moaning and sobbing as if his heart would break. But the first fit of rage passed off, Mr David Moses took a practical step. He called on Mr Jones, and the two went away together to Scotland Yard; there Jones described the strange would-be purchaser. The hard-featured 'chief' who listened to them smiled.

'That anything like him?' he asked, taking up an album and pointing to a portrait.

'The very man!' cried Mr Jones.

'Ah!' said the chief.—'Well, now, Mr Jones, be particular on one point. Did you keep your eye on the ring from Miss Levi's taking it from her safe till its coming into your hands?'

'No,' said Jones; 'I didn't. Miss Levi put the notes in the safe, and I was watching her for a second before the man passed me the ring.'

'Common trick,' said the chief—'changed it for a fac-simile.'

'But,' objected Jones, 'how could he make the fac-simile? The ring had only been in the window one day.—Had it, Mr Moses?'

'Only one day, ma tear—only one little day,' sighed the old Jew. 'O tear, O tear me!'

The chief set his lips very hard at this. 'Are the marks—hall-marks and so on, just the same?' he asked.

'Yes,' said Moses, 'and the gold too. It's only the stone.'

In the end, they went away, and the chief promised to do his best. He knew the stranger, who was a returned convict and a clever trickster. The mystery was the fac-simile of the ring. It implied previous acquaintance of a very

intimate type. In about a week Mr Moses received news: the real ring had been pawned in Manchester for five hundred pounds, and was now in possession of the Scotland Yard authorities. The latter had, they said, got a clue to the persons implicated; but they would say nothing more. When Moses was wanted, they would let him have word.

A week or two passed on, and one morning Mr David Moses received an urgent message asking him to go to Scotland Yard. The thieves, or whatever you would call them, were found. He called on Mr Jones, and set out with an exultant heart up the Strand.

‘Well,’ said the chief, ‘we’ve got ’em both. There are two of them. One is the man whose photo I showed you; the other is a young fellow who won’t give any name. He pawned the ring under the name of Morris.’

Moses thought that rather a coincidence; but he let the thought slip out of his mind, and smiled pleasantly when two policemen brought in the well-dressed gentleman who so tricked poor old Rachel. The *ci-devant* convict winked in a friendly fashion at Jones.

‘Did it well, eh?’ he said. ‘No good disguising it, I suppose? Reckon I’ll get a good dose for this.’

‘You’re right there, my friend,’ said the chief.—‘Take him away, sergeant, and bring the young man in.’

In a minute or two the men returned, leading in a young, loudly dressed man, who hung his head on his breast. Old Moses turned from examining a pair of handcuffs hanging on the wall, and discovered the thief of his cherished diamond to be—his son Solomon! The old man saw it all in a moment. His white face and chattering teeth showed the chief that something was wrong. The old Jew strove vainly to speak for a second or two; then he turned to the chief and stretched out his hands imploringly.

‘O Mr Inspector,’ he said, ‘it’s a mistake—it’s a terrible mistake, ma tear Mr Inspector! Don’t say no more about it, and I’ll—I’ll give *you* the tiamont—yes, O yes! Why, this is ma tear son Solomon!—O Solomon, my poy, how could you do it?’

‘Your son, eh?’ said the astonished chief. ‘Well, I’m sorry for you, old man; but the law must take its course.’



‘Oh, don’t say that,’ screamed Moses—‘don’t sir, don’t! I’ll give you the stone, and a thousand pounds besides! Let him go, sir.’

‘No; I haven’t the power.—Take him away, men.’ And they marched Mr Solomon off, while poor old David alternately wept and implored and raved, and beseeched the chief to have mercy on his ‘tear poy.’

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That night, they found poor David Moses, alias Mr Alfred Morris, dead in his little sanctum in Wych Street. The doctor said he had died of a sudden shock to the nervous system. We are of opinion that his son Solomon had given him a shock which broke his poor old heart.

## **A NEW ART-GUILD.**

An admirable proposal has lately been made at Liverpool for the formation of an 'Art-workers' Guild,' with the view to the diffusion of sound principles of decoration, and to the encouragement of workmen and others desiring to undertake decorative work of all kinds. The general object would appear to be to find good art-workmen, and to bring them into communication with those who require their work, and also to form a collection of good examples of decorative work of various kinds. Perhaps one of the best results of this sort of effort will be to bring forward the actual worker himself—the real artist, in fact—and thus get rid of the middleman or art-tradesman who hires the genuine artist to do the work, and then stamps it with his (the tradesman's) own name, as though the work were actually his own, whilst, in fact, he is merely the employer of highly trained and perhaps highly talented art-labour—a system at once as unfair as it is unjust. It has been said that the ugly patterns in calico-printing seem to sell as readily as the pretty ones; and one of the objects of the proposed Guild is to try to alter this—to endeavour to produce a better taste. But teaching a prejudiced and often ignorant public to improve itself on subtle questions and nice points of art-excellence is at best a difficult if not a hopeless task; and if the Guild raises the artist-worker to a better position and gives him direct employment, it will certainly be conferring a benefit on a worthy class of men, never yet properly recognised.

## A RETROSPECT.

I WAITED long;  
My love was strong  
For Cary.  
'In spring,' she said,  
The darling maid,  
'We'll marry.'

The winter passed;  
Spring came at last  
With showers.  
But what of them,  
When after came  
The flowers!

Our wedding-day,  
A grand array—  
Bells ringing!  
Blue sky above,  
Hearts full of love,  
Flowers springing.

My blushing bride  
And I beside  
The altar:  
She looked so nice,  
Although her voice  
Did falter.

Our honeymoon  
Ran all too soon  
Its measure:  
We roamed at will

By vale and hill,  
With pleasure.

And years have flown;  
We're wiser grown,  
And older;  
But aye the same  
Love's kindly flame,  
No colder.

As down we glide,  
Still side by side,  
Life's river,  
Each opening spring  
New joys will bring  
For ever.

J. B. L.

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